



HackIllinois 2026 Mentor Guide

Welcome!

Thank you for your interest in joining HackIllinois 2026 as a mentor! We are thrilled to have you on board this year! Our event is scheduled for February 27th to March 1st, 2026. Please make sure to join our Discord server [here](#). If you don't have an account already, you can sign up [here](#).

We hope you enjoy your experience with us this year!

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General Program Information

HackIllinois is a flagship collegiate hackathon with 13 years of history, hosted by the University of Illinois Urbana–Champaign — home to one of the top computer science programs in the country. As a fun fact, HackIllinois also was the first hackathon to introduce the concept of themed hackathons, a model now widely adopted across the hackathon community :)

Each year, we bring together top student engineers, designers, and founders from around the world to build projects that matter. At the start of the event, we provide opportunities for students to find groups to work in. During the hackathon, there will be a variety of events for students to attend, from tech talks to entrepreneurship-focused workshops. Attendees can also participate in our mini-events to destress and socialize with others. Mentor Office Hours will be available for students to ask technical questions during the event as they work on their projects. At the end, students will have an opportunity to demo their projects during the project showcase.

Many of these projects go on to become startups, research initiatives, or standout portfolio pieces.



General Program Information

The HackIllinois Project Showcase this year will feature 4 Tracks, 2 Paths, and additional prizes. Each group has a designated path and can choose at most one track to create a project for.

- **Path:** Categorized by hacker experience and skill level.
 - General - Open to all experience levels
 - HackVoyagers - Intended for advanced hackers
- **HackIllinois Prizes:**
 - Best Beginner Hack
 - Best Social Impact
 - Best UI/UX Design
 - Most Creative
 - Most Popular
 - Most Useless
- **Sponsored Track:** Project topics sponsored by companies.
 - **Stripe:** Best Web API
 - **Modal:** Best AI Inference
 - **Caterpillar:** Best AI Inspection
 - **John Deere:** Best Hardware Hack (John Deere Mechathon)
- **Sponsor Challenges:**
 - **Cloudflare:** Best Use of Cloudflare Developer Platform
 - **OpenAI:** Best Use of OpenAI API
 - **Capital One:** Best Use of Capital One Nessie (Hackathon API)
 - **Supermemory:** Best Use of Supermemory
 - **Solana:** Best Use of Solana
 - **Action:** Best Use of Action VectorAI DB
 - **Aedify:** Best Developed on Aedify
- **MLH Prizes:**
 - Best Use of Gemini API
 - Best Use of ElevenLabs
 - Best Use of Snowflake API
 - Best Use of DigitalOcean
 - Best Use of Presage
 - Best .Tech Domain Name

General Schedule

Below, you will find a consolidated list of all of our mentor events and important times that you may be interested in! More information about other events can be found on our [website](#)!

Mentor/Attendee Events

Day	Time	Event	Location
February 27th	2:00 PM - 5:00 PM	Check-in and Swag Pickup	Siebel 1st Floor
	9:00 PM - 10:00 PM	Project Ideation Session	Siebel Room 2405
February 28th	4:00 PM - 5:00 PM	Mentor/Judge Social	Siebel Room 3401
	5:00 PM - 7:00 PM	Astral Exhibition (Festival)	Siebel 1st Floor

Food/Logistics

Time	Location	Event
February 27th 6:00 PM - 7:30 PM	Siebel 2nd floor	Dinner (Jet's Pizza)
February 28th 11:00 AM - 12:30 PM	Siebel 2nd floor	Lunch (Mo's Burritos)
February 28th 6:30 PM - 8:00 PM	Siebel 2nd floor	Dinner (Shawarma Joint)
March 1st 11:30 AM - 12:30 PM	Siebel 2nd floor	Brunch (Jimmy Johns)

A dietary and allergen information guide with details for all food being served throughout the weekend coming soon.

Your Role as a Mentor

Mentors are intended to provide our attendees with guidance and support throughout the hackathon.

Here is a basic overview of what is expected of mentors:

- Mentors have to sign up for **at least 3 hours** of office hours [here](#). Students will ask for your help on various technical questions they have.
- Once mentors check in, they will receive a unique **QR code via email**. Attendees **must scan this code each time** they seek help. First-time office hours attendees will earn **50** points upon their initial scan.
- All mentors should bring a laptop for office hours and mentoring support.
- If you are staying for an extended period, please also bring any necessary personal belongings, toiletries, and other overnight essentials as needed.
- **Room 2406** will be designated for in-person mentors to provide office hours. In-person mentors are also free to roam around and assist attendees.
- **Room 2407** is designated as a mentor/judge lounge.
- Virtual mentors will be assisting attendees on the HackIllinois 2026 Discord server, where there will be both a text and voice channel. In-person mentors may join the text and voice channels as well.

Mentors are highly encouraged to participate in mentor events to further provide guidance and network with attendees.



Airport Options

Midway Airport (MDW)



Around 2 hours drive to campus

- **Peoria Charter:** book [here](#)
 - From: Midway Airport
 - To: Armory / ISR / Illinois Terminal
- **Amtrak**
 - From: CHI
 - To: CHM
- **Rental Cars**

O'Hare International Airport (ORD)



Around 2.5 hours drive to campus

- **Peoria Charter:** book [here](#)
 - From: O'Hare Multi-Modal Facility
 - To: Armory / ISR / Illinois Terminal
- **Amtrak**
 - From: CHI **(there's one hour CTA from ORD to the train station)**
 - To: CHM
- **Rental Cars**

Airport Options Cont.

Willard Airport (CMI)

 Around 15 - 20 mins drive to campus

Indianapolis International Airport (IND)

 Around 2 hours drive to campus

- **Jefferson Lines:** book [here](#)
 - From: IND | Indianapolis Union Station (Amtrak/Greyhound)
 - To: CHM | Champaign Intermodal Transportation Center
- **Amtrak**
 - From: IND
 - To: CHM
- **Rental Cars**

Note: If you're flying into an airport farther than ORD, be sure to book ground transportation to Champaign in advance.

Hotel Options

Close to HackIllinois:

Location Name	Address
Illini Union Hotel	1401 W Green St, Urbana, IL 61801
TownePlace Suites by Marriott	603 S 6th St, Champaign, IL 61820

A bit further:

You can take the bus ([free on and around campus](#)), Uber/Lyft from the hotel to the event, or bring a car if that is convenient for you.

Location Name	Address
I Hotel	1900 S 1st St, Champaign, IL 61820
Hyatt Place	217 N Neil St, Champaign, IL 61820

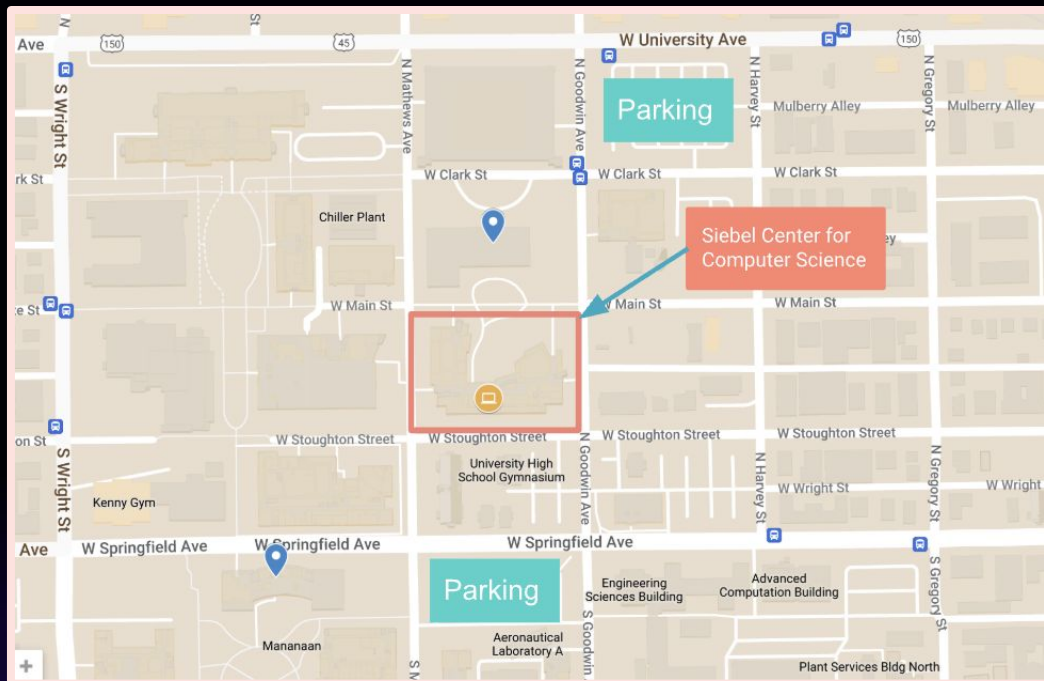
Reimbursement

- We reimburse travel and lodging on a case-by-case basis according to travel zones.
- If you would like to be considered for reimbursement, please indicate so in the **confirmation form**.
- You will book your travel and lodging depending on which options you choose, and we will refund the expenses through direct deposit or any method that is convenient for you (Venmo, Zelle, check).
- We will issue reimbursements **after the event**, so be on the lookout for an email. In order to issue reimbursements, we will ask for photos of all your receipts via a Google Form. If you do not receive an email within one week post-event, email us at operations@hackillinois.org.

Parking

For parking, there is visitor parking (free on weekends) available at the locations listed below. Additionally, metered parking is available in various locations around Siebel Center and campus.

Location Name	Address
National Center for Supercomputing Applications	1201 W University Ave, Urbana, IL 61801
Grainger Engineering Library	104 S Mathews Ave, Urbana, IL 61801

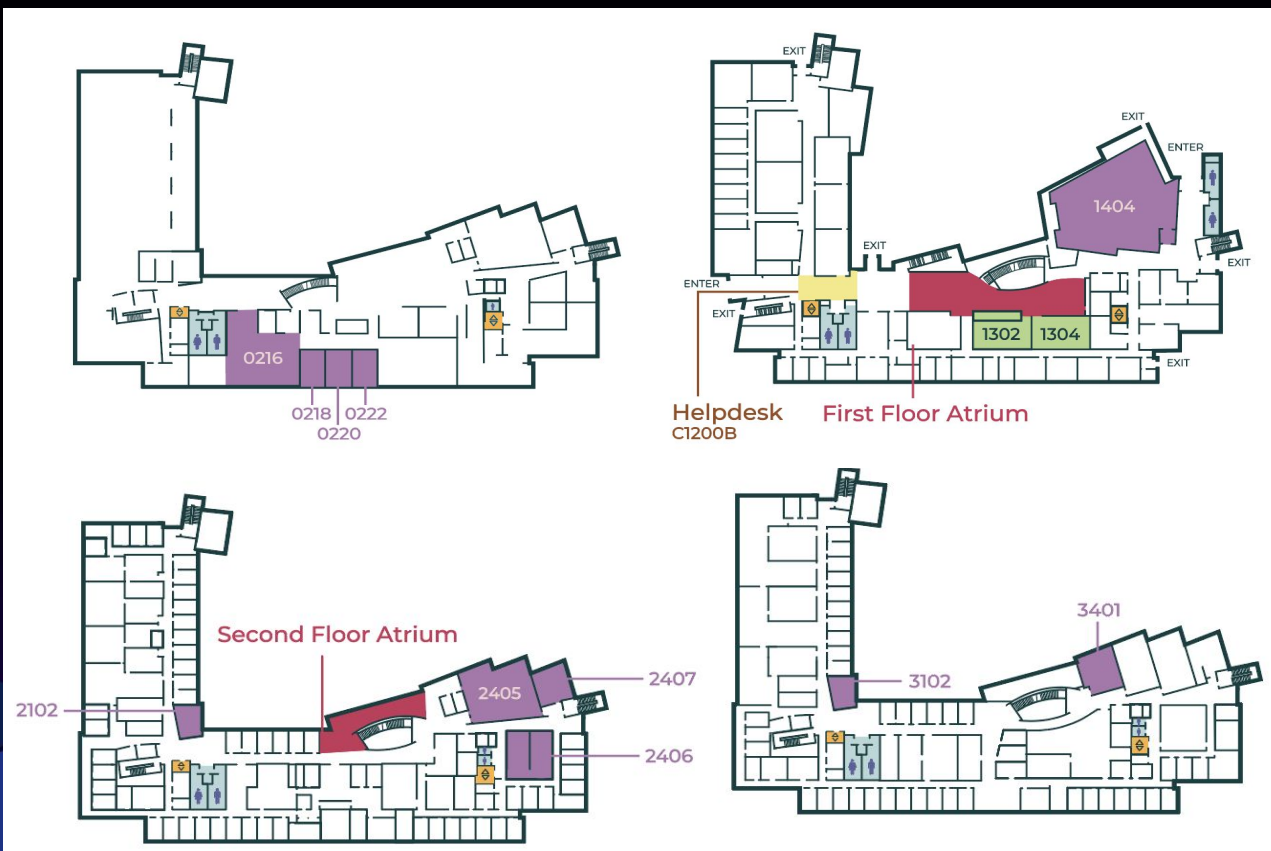


Event Navigation

After parking, enter the Siebel first floor and proceed to the atrium (the large open space located towards the center of the first floor, by the glass windows). If you check in during event hours (8 AM – 12 AM), staff members will be available to assist you. Just let them know you are a mentor/judge upon arrival!

A map of Siebel can be accessed [here](#).

Location Name	Address
Department of Computer Science (Siebel Center for Computer Science)	201 N Goodwin Ave, Urbana, IL 61801



Health & Safety

This year, the university does not require face coverings in classrooms or campus spaces. However, you are welcome to wear a face covering if you feel more comfortable doing so. For everyone's safety, there will also be police presences on campus throughout the event.

Emergency Contact Information

In case of an emergency and your assigned person of contact or an on-duty staff member is unable to be located/contacted, the following people can be contacted to resolve any issues:

Name	Role	Contact (Phone)
Shreenija Daggavolu	Experience Co-Lead	(309) 992-1078
Sada Challa	Co-Director	(217) 255-3289
Lucy Wu	Co-Director	(240) 328-2919

Recommended Eats & Drinks

During your time at HackIllinois, there are plenty of great options to grab a bite, enjoy a coffee, or sip on some boba. Below are some of our favorite local spots near campus for mentors, judges, and attendees alike.

Boba & Coffee

- **Cocomero** – Frozen yogurt, seasonal boba, and coffee
- **Latea Bubble Tea Lounge** – Classic milk teas and fruit teas
- **Brew Lab / Bake Lab** – Specialty coffee and espresso drinks

Food

- **Merry Ann's Diner** – Classic American breakfast and diner fare
- **Cracked: The Egg Came First** – Breakfast and brunch favorites
- **Shawarma Joint** – Middle Eastern wraps and plates
- **The Bread Company** – Cozy bistro and bakery
- **Sakanaya** – Sushi and Japanese cuisine
- **Northern Cuisine** – Highly rated Chinese cuisine
- **Seven Saints** – Popular bar & grill with sliders
- **Ko Fusion** – Asian fusion bowls, ramen, and sushi
- **Bangkok Thai** – Thai classics, curries, and noodle dishes



Thank you!

Thank you for taking the time to read through this guide. We are really excited to have you at the event! For more details and the official event schedule, please refer to the HackIllinois website [here](#). **Be sure to join the Discord server [here](#).** This will be our primary form of communication during the event.

If you have any questions about the information provided in this guide, please email operations@hackillinois.org. During the event, you will have an assigned Experience staff member to help and guide you through most events during the week. For any general assistance, visit the in-person help desks will be located at the Siebel Center for Computer Science first-floor entrance or use the HackIllinois 2026 Discord [#mentors-only](#) channel.

Thank you once again for all your help! We look forward to working with you and we sincerely hope that you have an enjoyable experience at HackIllinois this year.

